Associations and stories

Our associations

Associations are the connections that form between us and a colour almost by themselves. We are not born with a ready-made list “blue = this”, and yet some meanings repeat surprisingly often. They are usually made up of three layers. The body, culture and what we have lived through ourselves.

From the body

Blue is the colour of sky and water, that is of what is far away, deep and large. On a clear day it surrounds us from above and we do not have to strain in it. The eye reads it as cool and distant, but also as calm. Blue says. There is room here and no need to hurry.

From culture

Uniforms are blue and banks and hospitals use it. It is the colour of **trust** and **reliability**. At the same time we say we promise someone the blue from the sky when there is no firm basis behind it, and the English *feeling blue* means **sadness**. One colour thus manages both **trust** and **longing**. What we read in it depends also on where we grew up.

From what you have lived

The sea from a holiday, a school or work uniform, a blue raincoat from childhood, a swimming pool, a hospital corridor, jeans you felt good in. These are associations with your own signature. Two women can look at the same sea and one feels freedom, the other **fear** of **depth**. The colour is the same. The story is not.

When you know where your associations come from, it is easier to tell what is blue and what is your story about it.

A question for you

“What does blue connect with first for you?”

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Stories

The blue that cost more than gold

For a long time blue was obtained from the precious stone lapis lazuli, which was mined in the valleys of Badakhshan in present-day Afghanistan. The pigment reached Europe by sea, and that is why it got the name ultramarine, from the Latin *ultramarinus*, "from overseas". In the Renaissance it was among the most prestigious and dearest colours, sometimes valued as highly as gold. Painters therefore often reserved it for the robe of the Virgin Mary.

Artificial ultramarine could be produced only in the 19th century. Jean-Baptiste Guimet developed a process in 1826 but kept it secret, and in 1828 Christian Gmelin published his process. Since then blue has been available even to a painter without a rich patron.

The colour Homer did not write about

The Greek *oînops póntos*, often translated as "wine-dark sea", appears in Homer in both the Iliad and the Odyssey, often with a stormy sea. Blue does not appear in his descriptions of nature. William Gladstone explained this in 1858 by saying that the ancient Greeks described light and dark rather than shades. A similar observation about other old texts was developed in the 1860s by Lazarus Geiger and in 1969 by Brent Berlin and Paul Kay in the study *Basic Color Terms*. According to them languages add words for colours gradually and blue tends to be among the last.

That does not mean the ancient Greeks did not see blue. They just may not have had a separate word for it, and not every theory that grew out of this is taken literally today. What is interesting is that the name of a colour influences how we think about it.

Why the sky is blue

The blue sky is not a dye. Sunlight is scattered in the atmosphere on air molecules and shorter wavelengths (blue) are scattered more than long ones. This is called Rayleigh scattering. We see the sky as blue because blue light reaches us from all directions. At sea it is different. Water absorbs rather the red part of the light and returns blue, so the colour of the sea is also influenced by **depth**, the sky above it and tiny particles in the water.

Blue is, moreover, relatively rare in nature as a pigment. Much blue plumage or many butterfly wings are blue thanks to a structure that bends light, not thanks to a dye. Blue eyes also contain no blue pigment, the colour is created by the scattering of light in the iris.

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